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6. Find a planner that will work for you

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Depending on what you chose in #1, this either means a person or a book. Either way, choose someone/something you can work with, and whose interpersonal skills/interface works for you. I ended up making my own, out of a three-inch notebook and some plastic dividers, because I couldn't find one that didn't a) stress me out entirely; b) confuse the crap out of me; or c) make me want to puke with the number of pastel flowers on its cover. Sure, it's an initial expense, but most of them let you see how much you're spending in different areas and allow you to budget easier.

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7. Decide on the "look" and "feel" of your wedding

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This keeps you from buying things that later don't fit with what you want. Do you want something casual or formal? Classic or trendy? Carefree or chic? Mine was casual, laid-back, and carefree, while still being simple and elegant.

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8. Determine how much you can spend

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This can be a little awkward and unwieldy, what with your money,

your fiancé's money, any money from parents or other relatives who want to contribute, and any investments you might be including, but it's worthwhile to do, early on, so you don't get your heart set on something you just can't afford, or find that you can't have *any* flowers because you already chose such an elaborate cake.

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9. Make a budget, but make your own budget

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Many bridal services will tell you that you should spend a certain percentage of your available wedding funds on X, another percentage on Y, and yet another on Z. I tried this, but it didn't work. I spent *way* more on my dress than I should have, given my budget, but *way* less than they recommended for my reception. But I spent based on my priorities, and I was happy with the results.

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10. Find people to whom you can delegate

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If you find them at the beginning, you won't have to find them at the end. And they're essential. Give them a little something special for helping out.

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11. Laugh a little

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Seriously, relax. I realized part of the way through my planning process that